

CUB SCOUT PACK 376

ARROW OF LIGHT Parent Guide

5th Grade • 2026–2027 Scouting Year

As of the 2024 program update, Arrow of Light is its own rank tied strictly to 5th grade. It is the final Cub Scout rank and the bridge to Scouts BSA.

Welcome to the Arrow of Light year — the final and most adventurous year of Cub Scouting! Fifth graders work as a patrol, complete a required overnight campout and a two-hour service project, learn real first aid, and visit Scouts BSA troops as they prepare to cross over. This is the most outdoors-focused year, so a little family planning helps. Here's what to expect.

How Your Scout Earns the Arrow of Light Badge

To earn the Arrow of Light rank badge, your Scout completes all 6 required Adventures below, plus at least 2 elective Adventures of their choosing. Most requirements are completed together as a den at meetings, pack events, campouts, service projects, and troop visits. Your den leader tracks progress and gives final sign-off.

The 6 Required Adventures

Adventure	What your Scout will work on	Where
Bobcat <i>Character & Leadership</i>	Form a patrol and elect a leader, recite the Scout Oath and Law, learn Scouts BSA signs, slogan, and motto, visit a Scouts BSA troop, and complete the child-protection booklet at home.	Den / Patrol + Home
Outdoor Adventurer <i>Outdoors</i>	Take part in an overnight campout — pack gear, set up camp, keep food safe, and follow the Outdoor Code. (This is the year's required overnight.)	Pack / Troop campout
Personal Fitness <i>Personal Fitness</i>	Cook a camping meal, track 14 days of activity, do 30 minutes of stretching and moving, and review the health form with you.	Home + Den
Citizenship <i>Citizenship</i>	Plan and carry out a service project totaling at least two hours, using the Scouting America SAFE Checklist.	Pack
First Aid <i>Personal Safety</i>	Watch the Protect Yourself Rules video, handle “hurry cases,” choking, and shock, treat common injuries, and build a personal first-aid kit.	Den + Home
Duty to God <i>Family & Reverence</i>	Connect a family faith value to the Scout Law, meet a faith-based community helper, and discuss what “Duty to God” means to you.	Family

Family & Reverence note: this adventure can also be earned by completing the religious emblem of your family's choosing.

Choosing Elective Adventures (pick at least 2)

Your Scout chooses at least 2 of these to round out the year. The den usually does a few of them together, and your Scout can add more for fun or to earn extra recognition:

Elective Adventures

Champions for Nature • Cycling • Engineer • Estimations • Fishing • High Tech Outdoors • Into the Wild • Into the Woods • Knife Safety • Paddle Craft • Race Time • Summertime Fun • Swimming

Range & Target Sports (Archery, BB Gun, Slingshot): optional electives that may only be completed at approved council- or district-operated events with qualified range personnel — not at regular pack meetings.

Year at a Glance — What to Plan For

Here's the quick summary of the bigger commitments across the year. Arrow of Light Scouts should start visiting troops in the fall and are designed to cross over to a troop between January and March.

Troop visits & crossover	Visit Scouts BSA troops in the fall as part of Bobcat. The Arrow of Light program is designed to prepare 5th-grade Scouts to join a troop between January and March.
Overnights	One overnight campout is REQUIRED this year as part of the "Outdoor Adventurer" Adventure. The pack and troop organize campouts you can use — plan to attend at least one.
Service project	A service project totaling AT LEAST two hours is required (one project, or several adding up to two hours). This is the only rank with a minimum service-hour requirement.
Outdoor / biking / paddle	An overnight campout (above) plus outdoor electives if chosen. Cycling includes a 10-mile bike ride. Paddle Craft requires passing the Scouting America swimmer test before completing the on-water requirements.
Swimming & water	Optional only — the Swimming Adventure includes Safe Swim Defense and attempting the swimmer test; passing it is not required for Swimming. Paddle Craft uses Safety Afloat and does require passing the swimmer test for later requirements.
Shooting sports	Optional only — Archery, BB Gun, and Slingshot are available only at approved council- or district-run events with qualified range personnel.
Parent involvement	Not required at every meeting. This year leans outdoors, so please plan ahead for the required campout, troop visits, and service project.

What We Need From You at Home

A few items are completed at home with your Scout. Most other requirements are completed through den meetings, pack activities, troop visits, campouts, service projects, and other scheduled Scouting activities:

- Complete the "How to Protect Your Children from Child Abuse: A Parent's Guide" booklet activities (part of Bobcat).
- Watch the Arrow of Light Protect Yourself Rules video together.
- Review the BSA Annual Health and Medical Record together (part of Personal Fitness).

- Discuss your family's faith values and what "Duty to God" means (part of Duty to God).
- Plan ahead for the required overnight campout, two-hour service project, troop visits, and crossover timing.

Troop Transition Timeline

Arrow of Light is the bridge from Cub Scouts to Scouts BSA. A simple family planning timeline looks like this:



- **Fall (Sept–Nov):** Begin Bobcat, visit Scouts BSA troops, and learn about local troop options.



- **Winter (Dec–Feb):** Complete required Adventures, service hours, and the required overnight campout; choose the troop your Scout plans to join.



- **Crossover (Jan–Mar):** The Arrow of Light program is designed to prepare 5th graders to join Scouts BSA during this timeframe. Pack 376 will work with families to plan crossover and troop registration.

Tips for a Great Year

- Come to den and pack meetings — that's where most Adventures are earned.
- Watch for the pack calendar so you can plan around campouts, troop visits, the Pinewood Derby, and service projects.
- Keep the handbook handy and celebrate each Adventure as it's completed.
- Ask your den leader anytime you're unsure what's coming up next.

Questions? Reach out to your den leader or pack leadership — we're glad to help.